



her potential.

"He gave me the confidence to go up the pitch and have a free role in midfield," Sangita reveals.

That decision bore fruit in the 29th minute against Thailand. Anju Tamang passed the ball to an onrushing Sangita, who took a touch and half-volleyed it into the far corner from outside the box. Her second goal – the winner in the 74th minute – was a team move straight off the training ground.

Brushing up on the basics

"The set piece goal which Sangita scored, it was done for 53 days in training and then in three matches,

but it came in use in the fourth match. That's why longer camps are always helpful," India head coach Chhetri says.

In the lead-up to the qualifiers in Thailand, the Blue Tigresses trained at the Padukone-Draavid Centre for Sports Excellence in Bengaluru for almost two months. The extended camp allowed the team to play practice matches against local sides and two international friendlies against Uzbekistan, each ending in a 0-1 loss.

Chhetri, who took charge in late January, believes such long camps are particularly important in the context of Indian women's football,

Merit over miracles: The Indian women's football team scripted history by qualifying for the AFC Asian Cup on merit for the first time, toppling higher-ranked Thailand in a decisive showdown. AIFF MEDIA

where tactical basics are often underdeveloped.

"Women's football and men's football are completely different. The latter is thoroughly professional; they earn money in crores. But when it comes to women, as soon as the IWL is over, they are not that professional to take care of themselves," points out Chhetri.